

Backup (www.educ.umu.se/~cobian/cobianbackup.htm) is a simple yet versatile backup tool, for instance. Driveimage XML (www.runtime.org/driveimage-xml.htm) is a more than adequate replacement for Windows Complete PC Backup that will quickly create a complete image of your drive. And Windows Vista Home Basic or Premium users can gain access to shadow copies by installing Shadow Explorer (www.shadowexplorer.com), although we would recommend trying File Hamster instead (www.mogware.com/FileHamster). This clever program monitors the folders and files you specify, and keeps a copy whenever they are changed or overwritten, so if you lose something important then it's easy to recover a previous version.

Bundled applications

At first glance the bundled Windows Vista applications seem impressive. You can keep track of your schedule with Calendar, run Gadgets on the Sidebar or manage your digital images with Photo Gallery, for instance. And although good old Minesweeper is still there, it's joined by some graphically gorgeous games that you might actually want to play.

Look a little closer, though, and the news isn't all good. Built-in apps like Notepad and Paint are still chronically short on features, for example, and the supposedly new Windows Mail is really just Outlook Express with a very thin disguise. The inclusion of Windows Media Centre isn't all it seems, either – this only comes with the Windows Vista Home Premium or Ultimate editions. Everyone else must rely on Media Player to handle their videos and music.

Overall the built-in applications compare poorly with Linux, which includes powerful tools such as Evolution (email, address book and calendar functionality, the Linux answer to Microsoft Outlook) or Open Office (word processor, spreadsheet, presentation tools), and provides easy access to many more. There's no need to buy other software, you can be productive with a Linux system from the first time you turn it on.

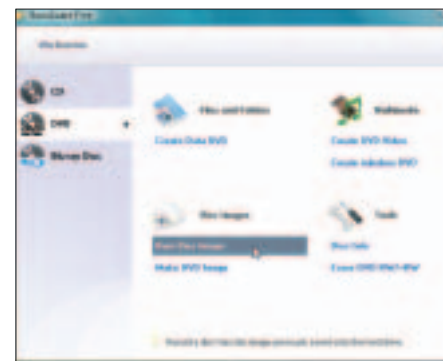
Still, there's nothing here that a little judicious downloading can't solve. Swap Notepad for Editpad Lite (www.editpadpro.com/editpadlite.html) and you'll get better performance, unlimited undo and redo, and a tabbed interface that allows you to open several files at the same time. Replace Windows Paint with Paint.Net (www.get-paint.net), a feature-packed image editor that's still easy enough for

beginners to use. Windows Mail is not nearly as configurable an email client as Thunderbird (www.mozilla-europe.org/en/products/thunderbird), which can be extended with hundreds of custom add-ons. Mediaportal (www.team-mediaportal.com) is a Media Center-like suite that can play videos, DVDs, music and internet radio. And if you need a professional word processor or spreadsheet then just grab a copy of Open Office (www.openoffice.org) – it's completely free.

Easily find updates

You can get around Windows' feeble bundled applications by installing replacements, then, but that only highlights another flaw – Windows Vista has almost no software management features.

If a Linux user wants to install or upgrade a program then in many cases they don't have to waste time searching online, manually downloading files or running installation programs. Instead they just run their package manager, choose the program they want from a menu, then it's downloaded, installed and later upgraded automatically. There's no fuss, no hassle or complications, it all just works.



Burnaware Free offers far more CD, DVD and Blu-ray burning features than you'll get with Windows Vista

There are no package managers that deliver the same level of functionality for Windows Vista, unfortunately, but we've found some tools that can at least make it easier to locate updates for your applications. Install the File Hippo Updatechecker (www.filehippo.com/updatechecker), for instance, and it'll scan your PC checking for installed applications, then report back any that have updates available (there's even a download link). It's a simple way to find out about the latest versions of your favourite applications and get their new features, bug fixes and speed improvements, without having to keep popping back to their website to check on what's available.